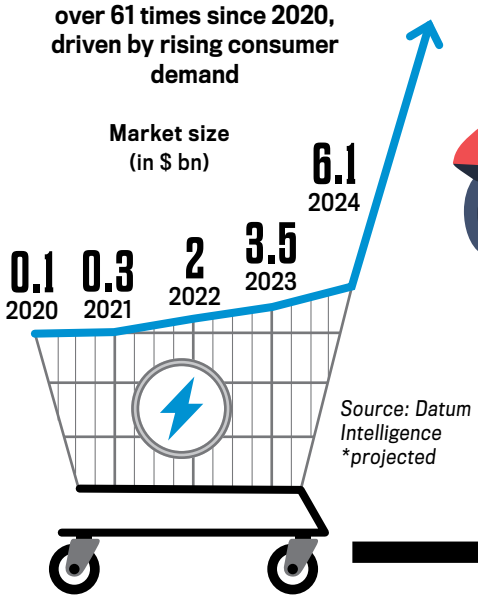
The Age of Instant Mart

QUICK COMMERCE IS REVOLUTIONISING SHOPPING IN INDIA, BY OFFERING ULTRA-FAST DELIVERIES RESHAPING CONSUMER EXPECTATIONS AND HABITS

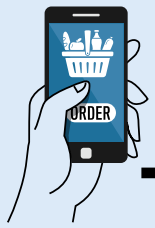
QUICK CURVE

The market has expanded over 61 times since 2020, driven by rising consumer demand



Source: Datum Intelligence
**projected*

HOW FAST DELIVERY WORKS



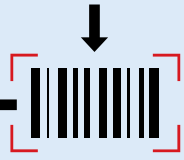


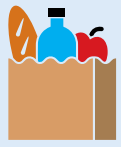


1. A consumer places an order, which the software assigns to the nearest dark store, located every 3-5 km in residential areas

2. The order is automatically assigned to a packer in the dark store, which maintains almost 20,000 products

3. Employees carry a device that shows them the most efficient route through the corridors in the dark store







4. Each product packed in 2 minutes undergoes barcode scanning, which updates the backend inventory system to forecast demand at the dark store

5. Once all the products are put in the brown bags, they are placed on wall-to-wall racks, ready for delivery

On the basis of the real-time demand, goods are re-stocked at dark stores multiple times a day from large warehouses located outside the city



THE GAME CHANGERS

Currently, three key players—Zomato's Blinkit, Swiggy Instamart and Zepto—dominate the q-commerce market, with shares of 40-45 per cent, 20-25 per cent and 15-20 per cent, respectively, according to brokerage firm UBS. Already, 'Zepto it', 'Blink it', and 'Instamart it' have become verbs in their own right, signifying the everyday act of ordering on q-commerce platforms in Indian households.

Initially focused on groceries, snacks and drinks, q-commerce platforms are branching into new categories as consumer interest grows. Now, they offer basic apparel such as undergarments, T-shirts and socks, along with footwear like flip-flops and sandals. Daily-use items such as stationery, toys, earbuds, irons, mixer-grinders, electric kettles, fans and computer peripherals are also part of their expanding inventory. In a survey of 3,032 online buyers by Datum, 58 per cent of the respondents said they used q-commerce platforms for grocery needs for the full month, 52 per cent said it came in handy for top-ups while 43 per cent used it for unplanned purchases.

For q-commerce platforms, tapping into consumers' growing desire for instant gratification is key. "As these companies have pincode-level data on consumer behaviour, they are focused on targeted selling so that they don't have to hold inventory for long," says Satish Meena, advisor at Datum. For instance, during Navratri, Zepto sold over 100,000 dandiya sticks, while Akshay Tritiya saw sales of 20 kg of gold and silver coins. On Dhanteras, items like brooms, considered auspicious, were in high demand. Over the past year, Zepto has increased its 6,000 stock-keeping units (SKUs) to 25,000.

The rapid growth of q-commerce is disrupting traditional retail dynamics. Though unorganised retail—kirana stores and local vendors—still dominates the grocery market, holding a massive 92.2 per cent share, q-commerce is gaining ground and already accounts for 1 per cent of the market. In comparison, the two-decade-old e-commerce holds just 1.3 per cent market share, while organised retailers like Spencer's, Reliance Fresh and DMart control 5.5 per cent. A Datum report predicts that by 2028, q-commerce's market share will rise by 2.4 per cent, fuelled by a 4 per cent decline in the market share of kirana stores.

"Consumers today are using quick commerce as their neighbourhood market, searching for all kinds of essential products," says Seshu Kumar Tirumala, chief buying and merchandising officer at BigBasket. BigBasket, which typically